

Growing Old in Australia

How a nation prepares for an ageing population

Goal (assigned briefing)

Explore Australia's ageing population and aged care services. Compare residential care, home care, and population ageing across different years, and investigate how demand for aged care is changing over time and across the country.

Target audience

Australian policymakers, aged care planners, and members of the general public who want to understand how demand for aged care is changing, who relies on the system, and where it is under the most pressure. The visualisation assumes no statistical background, so it favours clear, familiar chart types and plain-language annotations over dense or specialised idioms.

Data sources

Australian Institute of Health and Welfare (AIHW) GEN Aged Care Data for aged care recipients, care types, remoteness, and spending, and Australian Bureau of Statistics (ABS) population estimates for the ageing-population figures.

Layout and story approach

The visualisation is a single vertical scrolling story, sketched in two columns split by a wavy line and intended to become one column in the final version. It is read top to bottom: an introduction that frames the problem, six main sections that each build the argument with one chart, and a conclusion that draws the threads together. Every section is a self-contained topic with its own heading, a short block of explanatory text, and a labelled chart, so a reader can follow the story without prior knowledge. Name, student ID, studio number, and date sit in a box at the foot of the page.

Sections

1. Introduction

Sets the scene and states the question the piece answers. Australia's population is ageing quickly, the number of older people is climbing, and demand for aged care is rising with it. This section uses the title, subtitle, a short introductory paragraph, and a small illustrative figure to draw the reader in before any data appears.

2. An ageing nation

A line chart of the population aged 65 and over across time, with three lines for the 65+, 75+, and 85+ cohorts. The x axis is year and the y axis is population in millions. It shows the steady climb of all three groups and the especially fast growth of the oldest (85+)

cohort, which drives the most intensive care needs. A line chart is used because position and length are the most accurate channels for reading a trend over time.

3. Where people are cared for

A stacked area chart of aged care recipients by program type over the years, with bands for residential care, home care, and home support. The x axis is year and the y axis is the number of recipients. It shows both the overall growth in recipients and the shift in the mix towards home-based care. The known limitation, that bands stacked on top of others are harder to read precisely, is acknowledged.

4. Who uses aged care

A population pyramid of aged care users by age band and sex, with age bands on the y axis, the number of people on the x axis, males on the left and females on the right. It reveals the skew towards older women, who dominate the oldest age bands because they live longer, which has direct consequences for the kind of care the system must provide.

5. City and country gap

A horizontal bar chart of usage by remoteness, using the Modified Monash Model from metropolitan through to very remote. The y axis is the remoteness category (an ordered attribute) and the x axis is recipients per 1,000 people aged 65 and over. Rates are normalised per 1,000 rather than shown as raw counts, so population size does not distort the comparison. It highlights the uneven access between city and country.

6. Paying for it

A line chart of government spending on aged care over time, with year on the x axis and spending in Australian dollars (billions) on the y axis. It shows the rising cost pressure that accompanies growing demand, connecting the human story to the fiscal one.

7. State by state

A grouped bar chart comparing aged care provision across the states and territories, with state on the x axis and a rate such as recipients per 1,000 on the y axis. The grouped bars compare two years, or two care types, side by side, giving a direct read of how provision differs across the country.

8. Conclusion

Draws the argument together: an ageing population, a shift towards home-based care, uneven access shaped by geography, and rising cost. It states what these patterns mean for future planning, supported by a short summary paragraph and two or three headline figures.